

Lining

Underlying fabric used to give a neat finish to an item.

Medallion

A style of quilt in which a large central motif is surrounded by several borders.

Mirrorwork

Also called shisha work, a traditional form of textile decoration from Central Asia and India that involves stitching around or over small discs of mirror, glass, or tin to hold them in place on the fabric.

Mitre

To finish a corner by stitching adjacent sides of fabric together at a 45-degree angle. Or, the diagonal line made where two edges of a piece of fabric meet at a corner, produced by folding.

Muslin

Fine, plain, open-weave cotton.

Nap

The raised pile of fabric made during the weaving process, or a print on a fabric which runs one way. When cutting out pattern pieces, ensure the nap runs in the same direction.

Overcasting

Also known as whipstitch, this is a hand stitch used particularly in English paper piecing.

Patch

An individual piece of fabric used in making a patchwork design. Patches may be whole squares or rectangles, or subdivided into triangle units, curved units, or combinations thereof.

Patchwork

The technique of stitching together small pieces of fabric to make a larger one.

Pile

Raised loops on the surface of a fabric, for example, velvet.

Plain-weave fabric

A tightly woven fabric in which the warp and weft form a simple criss-cross pattern. The number of threads in each direction are not necessarily equal. Examples of plain-weave fabrics include cotton, linen, and silk.

Presser foot

The part of a sewing machine that is lowered on to the fabric to hold it in place over the needle plate while stitching. There are many different types of feet available.

Quilting

The process of stitching the three layers of a quilt (top, wadding, and backing) together. In addition to serving a practical purpose in holding the three layers together, the quilting stitch pattern often forms an integral part of the quilt design. It is normally marked out on the quilt top in advance and may consist of a geometric grid of squares or diamond shapes, concentric lines that echo shapes within the design, intricate shapes such as hearts, feathers, and swags, or a continuous meandering pattern.

Quilting guide

Also known as a quilting bar. An I-shaped metal bar which attaches to the back of the presser foot and allows a quilter to stitch evenly

spaced lines by following the previous line of quilting stitches. The bar can be adjusted to different widths.

Quilt sandwich

The three layers of a quilt: the top, wadding, and backing. The quilt top and backing form the "bread" of the sandwich and the wadding forms the filling.

Raw edge

Any cut edge of fabric. Raw edges are usually hidden in seams or turned under and hemmed or stitched in place, as in appliqué. Some techniques depend for their effect on leaving the raw edge unstitched.

Reef knot

A type of double knot which is made symmetrically by tying a single knot with right over left, then a second single knot with left over right, or vice versa. Also known as a square knot.

Registration marks

The marks on a sewing pattern that should be transferred to the fabric when cutting out. They are often in the form of notches, with the notches on one pattern piece corresponding to the notches on other pattern pieces, acting as a guide for matching, pinning, and sewing two pattern pieces together accurately.

Reverse stitch

Machine stitch that stitches backwards over a row of stitches to secure the threads.

Right side

The front of a piece of fabric, the side that will normally be in view when the piece is assembled.

Rocking stitch

The ideal stitch for hand quilting in which the needle takes several stitches up and down vertically before pulling the thread through.

Running stitch

A simple, evenly spaced, straight hand stitch separated by equal-sized spaces, used for seaming and gathering.

Sashing

Strips of fabric interspersed between blocks when making a quilt top.

Seam

The join formed when two pieces of fabric are sewn together.

Seam allowance

The amount of fabric allowed for on a pattern where sections are to be joined together by a seam. The standard seam allowance in patchwork is 6mm (¼in).

Seam edge

The cut edge of a seam allowance.

Seamline

The line along which a seam should be stitched.

Seam ripper

A small, pointed, hooked tool with a blade on the inside edge of the hook used for undoing seams and unpicking stitches.

Seam roller

Tubular pressing aid for pressing seams open on fabrics that mark.